Office of Research Assurance

Human Subject Research Protections Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP- 435: Changes to Approved Research

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Versions
435	5/21/2025	v.2	v.1

Purpose

SOP-435 defines the processes and procedures for reviewing changes previously approved by the NASA Institutional Review Board (IRB) for non-exempt human subjects research protocols and study documents. Changes are also known as amendment and modification, interchangeably.

Policy

1. Researchers may not initiate changes in research procedures, consent forms/processes, or other project related documents for non-exempt research without prior NASA IRB review and approval, except when necessary to eliminate apparent immediate hazards to the research participants.
2. Examples of amendments that require NASA IRB review include, but are not limited to:
    a. Study team members;
    b. Recruitment materials;
    c. Research procedures;
    d. Participant populations, including enrollment numbers;
    e. Research location;
    f. Consent form/process;
    g. Procedures to maintain privacy or confidentiality
3. Some exempt research may require IRB approval of changes, see ORA 420.
4. If a researcher makes changes to eliminate apparent hazards to the research participant(s) without prior NASA IRB approval, the researcher must promptly report the changes to the IRB for review and a determination will be made as to whether the changes to eliminate apparent hazard are related to the participant's continued welfare.
5. Discontinuation or completion of a project must be promptly reported to the NASA IRB. See ORA 450, Study Closure.

Procedures

1. Principal Investigators (PI) request prospective IRB review and approval from the NASA IRB for all changes to approved non-exempt human subjects research (and some exempt research per ORA 420) through the eIRB.
2. The PI must complete the modification smart form, describe all changes in the modification summary section, and include supporting documents.
3. NASA IRB Office responsibilities
    a. **Screening/pre-review.** Upon receipt of the submission in the eIRB the NASA IRB office staff will conduct a pre-review.
        i. During pre-review the submission may be returned to the PI for questions, clarifications, or updates. The NASA IRB Office may consult with senior staff, IRB Chairs, and members as needed, particularly with respect to assessments of risks and benefits.
        ii. When pre-review is complete, IRB Staff will forward the modification submission to the convened IRB for full board review or to a designated reviewer for expedited review.
        iii. For studies under FDA purview, where changes impact FDA related determinations, modification submissions will be forwarded to the convened IRB for review.
    b. **Review.** IRB Staff will determine the applicable type of review (e.g. convened board or expedited) based on the types of changes requested (see SOP-430 for types of amendments/changes).
        i. Administrative changes can be reviewed and approved by IRB Staff using the expedited review procedure.
        ii. Minor changes can be reviewed using the expedited review procedure (See ORA 430). Expedited reviewers exercise all authority except to disapprove the modification. Reviewers may also refer review to the convened IRB.
        iii. All other changes that are neither administrative nor minor will be reviewed by the convened NASA IRB. The convened IRB will follow procedures outlined in ORA 410, applying approval criteria as applicable.
    c. **Review Outcomes**
        i. For expedited review, outcomes are the same as those outlined in ORA 430. IRB Staff will notify the PI of the decision in writing (via the online submission system). A listing of the submission will be presented to the IRB at the monthly meeting to advise the IRB of the review.
        ii. For convened board review, outcomes are the same as those outlined in ORA 410. IRB Staff will notify the PI of the decision in writing (via the online submission system).
        iii. Acknowledgement/approval does not change the study expiration date.
        iv. If the PI has concerns regarding the IRB's decision, he/she/they may submit concerns to the IRB in writing, including a justification for changing the IRB's decision.

Definitions

Modification/Amendment – changes to the IRB approved protocol and project documents.

Administrative Modifications (am): non-material, administrative or typographic revisions (e.g., training documentation updates, study closures, addition of executed reliance documentation, local ethics documentation, typographic corrections) that may be reviewed and approved by NASA IRB office staff.

Minor Modifications (mm): changes to approved research that, in the opinion of the IRB reviewer, neither materially increase overall risk, nor materially decrease benefit; provided the proposed changes would not negatively impact prior determinations made by the IRB.

References

14CFR1230
21CFR50, 56, 312, 812

Version #	Version Notes:	Originated By:	Approved By:	Date Approved:
v.2	Major revisions	J. Green	M. Covington	21May2025
v.1		J. Kisenwether	M. Covington	9Aug2024